

MAPPING THE EVOLUTION OF A WICKED PROBLEM: FOOD INSECURITY IN PITTSBURGH

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY:

Looking back at history is important because understanding the systemic roots of food insecurity in Pittsburgh—from colonial legacies and slavery to industrialization, redlining, and climate change—is crucial for designing effective and equitable solutions. Transition Design principles guide us to address these interconnected challenges by fostering community resilience, promoting food sovereignty, and dismantling racist policies that

Food Insecurity in Pittsburgh: A Legacy of Injustice

We found that over one-third of Black residents in Pittsburgh live in Healthy Food Priority Areas, underscoring the disproportionate impact of food insecurity on this community. Therefore, it was imperative for us to start our timeline during early settler colonization and chattel slavery, as the damages of these imperial conquests are responsible for the deep-rooted conditions we face today. Indigenous communities, once thriving on sustainable food systems, were displaced and forced into dependency, creating long-lasting impacts. Similarly, slavery denied land ownership and farming opportunities to African Americans, perpetuating cycles of poverty and food insecurity.

The next major event exacerbating food insecurity was the rise of industrialization and deindustrialization. The opening of steel mills, exemplified by the Edgar Thomson Steel Works in Braddock, severed workers' connection to food production, making them reliant on industrial wages. When deindustrialization hit in the 1980s, towns like Braddock faced economic collapse, job losses, and the shuttering of grocery stores, leading to food deserts.

Adding to this devastation were the racially discriminatory practices that shaped Pittsburgh's urban landscape. The construction of highways, like the I-579 Expressway, physically severed the Hill District from economic opportunities and grocery access, displacing thousands of Black residents and businesses. These car-centric policies sidelined public transit investment, leaving low-income communities stranded and food insecure.

Finally, these deep rooted conditions were further complicated by our finding that climate change exacerbates these existing inequities. Extreme weather events disrupt food production, and the urban heat island effect disproportionately impacts marginalized neighborhoods, further limiting access to fresh, affordable food.

We were surprised that despite numerous community-led initiatives and interventions, such as urban farms and mutual aid networks, food insecurity persists in these historically marginalized neighborhoods, highlighting the need for systemic change. We learned that lasting solutions require addressing the root causes of food apartheid, including dismantling racist policies, promoting food sovereignty, and building resilient local food systems.

MAP KEY:

Infrastructure

Social

Environmental

Economic/ Business

Politics/ Governance/ Legal Politics/ Governance/ Legal issues are concerned with laws, policies and legal issues that are connected

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reg connections across all levels of the MLP framework

relationships that contribute to the above

LANDSCAPE

Landscape-level events are large-scale, collective forces—such as wars, natural disasters, globalization, and systemic inequalities—that shape cultural norms, technologies, and movements, impacting many people and exerting pressure on smaller-scale social issues.

REGIME

The Regime Level represents the entrenched status quo—societal systems like laws, policies, technologies, and established practices—that resist change but can be disrupted by pressure from larger landscape forces above and grassroots movements below.

NICHE

The Niche Level is where new ideas and innovations are tested in response to changes in higher levels; these small-scale experiments can gain traction and become mainstream when openings in the Regime allow them to "bubble up."

